

About the Project

This project focused on understanding how the City of Kingston currently manages grants and the challenges of a process that hasn't been designed to scale.

It was carried out across multiple research phases, using insights from the people involved to explore how a centralized portal could better support the system.



View our work



**FINAL
PROTOTYPE**



**JOURNEY
MAP**

Behind the Design

Joel Varghese

Research • Documentation • Design

Sahil Rajput

Research • Documentation • Design

Melvin Chibuzor

Research • Documentation • Design

Taylor Graham

Research • Documentation • Design

KEY INSIGHTS

01

BUILT ON DEDICATION, READY FOR BETTER TOOLS

At every stage, staff are manually bridging gaps that a well-designed system would handle automatically.

02

APPLICANTS DESERVE A CLEARER PATH FORWARD

Kingston's applicants deserve visibility into the process they are part of. A connected system means better communication, less confusion, and more trust.

03

KINGSTON IS READY FOR WHAT COMES NEXT

The foundation is strong, the people are committed, and a unified platform connecting intake, review, and reporting is the natural next step for a city that takes its community seriously.



X



City of Kingston *Grants Portal*

Mapping the Internal Grant Flow

This project focused on streamlining how the City of Kingston manages its internal grant programs, making the process more transparent, coordinated, and accessible for both City staff and the partner organisations supporting the community.

Prepared by:

- Joel Varghese
- Sahil Rajput
- Melvin Chibuzor
- Taylor Graham

Client:

City of Kingston, Grants Department

PHASE

01

ANALYSIS

We scanned five Canadian municipalities and reviewed grant management literature to build a research foundation before engaging City staff.

DIRECT COMPETITORS



- City of Thunder bay
- City of Kamloops
- City of Belleville

INDIRECT COMPETITORS



- City of Vancouver
- City of Ottawa
- City of Halifax

Key Insights

- Grant programs managed independently across departments with no shared visibility
- Applications handled through email and Excel, making tracking and review difficult
- Duplicate and ineligible applications often caught too late
- Incomplete applications require significant staff follow-up every cycle
- Post-approval reporting is entirely manual, adding ongoing workload to staff

PHASE

02

DESIGN

We conducted a focus group with five City staff members, ran a Thunder Bay case study, and mapped the full grant lifecycle to understand where breakdowns occur and design better solutions.

Focus Group Findings

Every department manages grants independently with no shared system, no visibility, and partner organisations carrying most of the admin load. Approving a grant is just the beginning of the work.

Impact reporting is inconsistent, equity outreach lacks infrastructure, and Thunder Bay proves a better system is entirely achievable.

Design Recommendations



Build a centralised portal connecting all programs, tracking, review, and reporting into one shared system for both city staff and partners



Adaptive application forms that guide applicants through exactly what they need, reducing confusion and incomplete submissions



Built-in post-award tracking and reporting so the work after approval is finally supported, not just expected

PHASE

03

EXECUTION

Team conducted interviews with Kingston Arts Council and United Way liaison, validating focus group findings with real operational experience.

Partners who were Interviewed



Kingston Arts Council



United Way KFL&A

Partner Insights

- Partner organisations manage the full grant lifecycle on the City's behalf, confirming that any effective portal must extend meaningful access and control beyond city staff alone
- The jury and adjudication process presents a clear opportunity for consolidation, replacing fragmented manual workflows with a single secure digital system for scoring, documents, and confidentiality
- Strategic alignment between the City and its funding partners currently relies on relationship and conversation, pointing to a clear integration opportunity within a consolidated portal

Grant Life Cycle



Grant Created



Application Submitted



Eligibility Review



Under Review



Funding Decision



Reporting & Outcomes



Closed